Truth in Dreams

by Joshua Sands

The dream always begins the same way. Darkness becomes light and I'm marching to the cadence of a drum commander: Left, left, left, right, left. Only I can never stay in step, always skipping a beat to get back with the cadence. The cadence gets faster. And faster. And faster. Suddenly, I'm out of control. I'm marching straight into a tree, only the tree doesn't stop me. It shatters like glass and I continue on. Light becomes darkness. The cadence slowly fades away: Left, left, left, right, left.

INTRODUCTION

I look in the mirror and say to myself:

"I look like me but I don't feel like me. Everything in my life seems to be changing. I'm not reacting the way I usually do. What's happening? Am I going crazy?"

No, I'm not. I'm going through one of the most intense, frightening and difficult emotional experiences of life and sometimes I believe that I've only just begun to find the Truth in Dreams by Joshua Sands.

My wife, Karen, and I are deeply in love. We only fight approximately three times per year. Sort of a tri-annual ritual, you might say. These fights usually involve money, taxes, or in-laws. Of course the third tight of this year falls into the" miscellaneous" category: we're fighting over my potency. See, we want to have a child but can't seem to make it happen. She says I'm not potent enough; I say let's try harder. She may be right, but I can't admit that. I mean, you're told that

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one of the reasons you enter this world is to reproduce. Pass something on. Leave it behind. Can't imagine not being able to do that. So we fight; I defend myself out of sheer masculinity. And we try again. You can have anything if you try hard enough, my dad always said.

Our lives have begun to resemble a First Response commercial. It's as if our life evolves around the stick. The plus or minus that determines our future. A plus represents the future. A family. A minus means something is subtracted. With each minus, we lose something: control, hope, dreams.

The dream begins to come into focus. Left, right, left. I'm no longer marching but the cadence is clear. I'm riding a bus. Karen is next to me. She wants to get off the bus but I won't let her so I hold her in her seat. The bus accelerates with the beat. Left, right, left. It hits the tree and the wood shatters like glass. Light becomes darkness.

When she exits the bathroom: Honey, you won't believe this but... What - we got a double minus this time? No honey, we've done it.' See for yourself! My life has evolved around the stick and the stick reads: plus. Positive. As if God were reaching down and saying, "OK, you can start your life now." Positive. Addition. A new addition. What are we gonna do first?

First, the mall. Second, Toys R' Us. They've got some really fine products! Nothing is too much for my kid. I got him a plastic ball and bat. What if it's a girl? Then we'll play softball! You know the baby won't be born ready to throw a curveball. I know. I buy everything I can think of. Things for the future. Additions. I always envisioned buying this deluxe swing set so we got one! Four swings, three slides - a teeter-totter. You know, we're only having one child! Yeah, but we're making this one count! Think we have an overzealous father on our hands! Well,

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maybe.

It was if time stood still and flew by simultaneously. Karen and I were planners -like we were coordinating a big convention when tons of people would soon arrive. There was only one arrival on the way, but we were planning for more. We were moving from couple to family. Philosophers argue that if you can find just a few days of absolute happiness, then you're fortunate. Karen and I found months of absolute happiness. In the midst of going to work, paying bills, and all the other mundane tasks, we had found joy. And the true joy was still on the way...

Then one October night, Karen's putting away the dinner dishes when she says: Honey, Oh my God! He's coming! Oh my God, he's coming! OK, I've prepared for this for months. I can do this. One: Get her bag with her things. Got it. Two: Call the hospital. Check. Three: Help Karen to the car. Check. The contractions are getting closer. It's almost time! I have to get her there! The way I normally would go to the hospital has a train blocking the road. U-turn. Oh my God! My water broke! Are things supposed to happen that quickly? Don't worry, dear, I'll get you there! I'm taking side roads - swerving back and forth passing the other cars quickly and accurately. Wait - shortcut! I turn left, and I see a car coming straight at me. I turn back. A car is bearing down from the other side. Left. No wait, right. No - left. Suddenly, I'm spinning around. Spinning. Spinning. Karen!

Karen? Karen? I'm not actually speaking, but screaming in my head. My brother is there.

Where am I?

Ryan, you're in the hospital. Save your breath.

The hospital? Did I get Karen here on time? Why don't I remember?

Ryan, you were in an accident. Ryan, it was bad. I don't know how to say this.

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Ryan, Karen didn't make it. I'm sorry Ryan.

What? My God - what have I done? I bring myself to say "Baby?"

Ryan, I'm really sorry. There was nothing anyone could do,

Nothing? You mean it's over? Over? Don't tell me that. Don't tell me they're gone. I thought, you know, maybe I'm hallucinating. Maybe I'm in a coma. Maybe. Bur I knew. I was in the hospital, the sole survivor of a bad accident. The result of a wrong turn - made by me: an overzealous father.

The dream crystallizes. The bus is a car. I'm driving the car. I swerve left. Then right. Then left again. No matter which way I turn, I am swerving the wrong way. Off beat. The tree has become a telephone pole. I reach over to hold Karen, trying to brace her from the crash. Light turns to darkness as the rescue unit breaks the car windows to save us. They say, "We can still save him but she's already gone." Gone. Addition becomes subtraction. Dream becomes nightmare.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
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